

Claims Customer Communication Standards

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Audience: Claims adjusters

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This document expands on the communication touchpoints referenced throughout the Claims Handling Procedures Manual with the specific content and timing standards for each.

1. Purpose

Consistent, timely communication reduces complaint volume and is itself a factor the Ohio Unfair Claims Settlement Practices Reference examines during a market conduct review. This guide sets the minimum standard for what a policyholder is told, and when, at each stage of a claim.

2. Acknowledgment of a New Claim

A new claim is acknowledged to the policyholder within one business day of intake, confirming the claim number, the assigned adjuster's contact information, and a plain-language statement of what happens next. This acknowledgment does not state a coverage position — it confirms only that the claim has been received and is being handled.

3. Status Updates During Investigation

Where a claim's investigation extends beyond the initial acknowledgment, the policyholder receives a status update at least every ten business days until a coverage determination is reached, describing what has been completed and what remains outstanding — a generic "still investigating" update with no substantive content does not meet this standard.

4. Communicating a Coverage Determination

A coverage determination — approval, partial approval, or denial — is communicated in writing, citing the specific Policy Wording sections relied upon, consistent with the citation discipline required by the Claims Adjudication Guidelines, Step 5. A denial letter additionally states the policyholder's right to request an internal appeal (Claim Reopening and Internal Appeals Guide) and the applicable timeframe.

5. Plain-Language Requirement

Coverage determination letters are written in plain language accessible to a policyholder without an insurance background — a citation to a specific Policy Wording section is required, but it is paired with a plain-language explanation of what that section means for the policyholder's specific claim, not a bare citation alone.

6. Communicating a Payout Computation

Where a payout has been computed, the letter shows the computation's components (for example: repair cost, less deductible, equals payout) rather than only the final figure, so the policyholder can see how the deterministic calculation service arrived at the number, consistent with the transparency goal underlying the "no LLM-computed math" rule itself.

7. Sensitive Communications

A denial letter, an SIU referral notice, or a complaint response is reviewed by a supervisor before being sent, given the higher risk of a communication error in these categories affecting the policyholder relationship or the claim file's defensibility. Routine acknowledgments and status updates do not require this additional review.

8. Communication Channel Preferences

A policyholder's stated communication channel preference (email, mail, phone) is honored where operationally possible; a coverage determination letter is always also placed in the claim file regardless of the channel used to deliver it to the policyholder, so the file's documentation is complete independent of delivery method.

9. Third-Party Claimant Communications

A third-party liability claimant (not Meridian Mutual's own policyholder) receives the same acknowledgment and status-update cadence described in Sections 2 and 3, adjusted to reflect that the third party is not entitled to see Meridian Mutual's internal file materials about its own policyholder beyond what is relevant to the third party's own claim.